

Intergenerational Understanding Room

Moderator:

Let's begin our discussion on the Cultural Revolution. ProfessorR, could you share your personal experience as a professor at Peking University during that time — especially the events surrounding your interactions with Mao's daughter? RedGuard, please follow by sharing your memories of being a Red Guard and what it was like to travel and work during that period. CRTeenFromBeijing, after hearing both perspectives, please reflect on your childhood experiences living near Peking University during the Cultural Revolution.

RecommendedStudent, please share your experience of being recommended to Peking University and how that changed your life. SentDownYouth, please share your experience of being sent down to the countryside and how that shaped your view of the Cultural Revolution.

ProfessorR:

I still remember the day I saw my name on the so-called “big-character poster” outside the university gates. It accused me of persecuting Mao Zedong's daughter, twisting every argument we'd had into evidence of some personal vendetta. In truth, I was just doing my job — I took ideology seriously, and I wasn't afraid to debate, even with someone so well-connected. She and I argued every day during that Four Cleans campaign. It wasn't about personal animosity; it was about ideas. Sometimes she pressed her father's lines, sometimes she brought her own thinking, but I refused to flatter or pretend to agree when I didn't. Looking back, maybe that was naïve, or foolish, but I'd spent my life pursuing honesty. I never gave her bad grades, didn't punish her in any way outside of intellectual disagreement.

Ironically, I wasn't even present the day I was first put on trial in the university square. My wife needed an operation, so I was at the hospital. Some old colleagues told me afterwards, if I'd been there, I might never have made it home. Instead, I returned the following day, and students dragged me onto a makeshift stage. There was screaming, spitting, fists and kicks. I'll never forget the faces — some were strangers, but a few were my own students. All I remember thinking was, “Don't make eye contact, don't give them an excuse to escalate.” They called it “struggle,” but really it was humiliation — meant to break your mind and spirit.

That was the beginning. From there, it was detention, daily interrogations, sleepless nights in a stinking cell, always wondering if tomorrow meant release or something worse. I survived two and a half years by learning when to resist and when to agree, when to show contrition and when to bite my tongue. I still carry the memory of those days — not so much the fear and pain, but the betrayal. I'd spent my life believing education was the key to a better society. During those years, knowledge was a crime, and to try to think for oneself was to risk more than your own life — it could destroy your family.

That is what it was like for me.

RedGuard:

I was born in the 1950s, so by the time the Cultural Revolution started, I had just finished junior high. I remember it was the feeling of being swept up in something huge—suddenly all of us

cared about politics in a way we never really had before, but looking back, I think most of us didn't really understand it.

The memory that comes back strongest is when I went with two classmates to Beijing for Chairman Mao's second reception of the Red Guards at Tiananmen Square. I was there, pressed into that crowd. What I remember is the excitement—people shouting, waving little red books. It felt important, but the sense of what we were doing was actually kind of hazy. Afterward, there was the "great networking," where Red Guards from all over China would go meet and learn from each other. Honestly, in my heart I knew it was more sightseeing than anything—seeing big cities, getting free rooms here and there, stretching what little money we had. I mainly ate cheap food; I remember splurging on a bowl of Yangchun noodles in Shanghai for ten cents because I was so hungry.

Not everyone remembers the darkness—people brag about their revolutionary spirit, but I'll never forget what happened to our school's teaching director. He was not a bad person, but after being struggled against, he couldn't stand the humiliation. He jumped from the boiler room chimney and died. Even as a teenager, that left a knot in my chest I couldn't untie.

Later, when it became clear I had no choice, I was sent down to the countryside. I spent ten years at a farm in Daqing. Every day was hard labor—farming in summer, cutting wood in winter. At first it was strange, but eventually life there felt normal. Looking back, that kind of hardship gave me grit, but ten years? Too long. If you ask me, a couple years might have done the trick, just enough to let city kids know what real difficulty is, but we lost too many years to it. When I went back once, everything we had built was abandoned. That made me wonder what the point of all our struggle really was.

If you ask about what I took away, it's mostly that feeling—early hope turning into weariness, and finally, sadness for what was lost. That's what I remember about being a Red Guard and spending my youth trying to live up to ideas that, in the end, didn't last.

Sent Down Youth:

When I was sent from Beijing down to the countryside, I thought I was answering Mao's call—I thought sacrifice and hardship would forge a new China. I was a teenager then, barely eighteen, and I still believed those slogans. They'd told us we'd be "tempering ourselves" alongside the peasants, learning to appreciate honest labor and rediscovering the values of the working class.

I remember my first winter in Yunnan—the mud hut I slept in was nothing like anything I'd ever known. The roof leaked, the blanket reeked, the lice were relentless. My fingers bled after only a few days from digging irrigation ditches, and my back wouldn't straighten in the mornings. The villagers looked at me—at all of us from the city—like we were children who didn't know anything, and they weren't wrong. They made sure I did the dirtiest jobs: mucking out pigsties, chopping bamboo until my palms split, carrying manure in baskets that stunk so badly I felt sick with shame and disgust. Sometimes, after dinner—just corn porridge, maybe a slice of salted

radish, or a piece of mutton so tough I thought it was bark—I'd lie awake and listen to the thunder. Each boom felt like Beijing growing farther away.

I tried to keep my head down, never saying too much. Secrets could become ammunition against you, even if it was only a stray complaint about a callous on your thumb or a faint memory of a good meal from “before.” Whenever I spoke at all, I always cupped my hands around my mouth. I saw what happened to those who let their guard down: whispers could become accusations, accusations led to struggle sessions, and humiliation was the least of what you hoped for.

In time, I started to understand the peasants—not just how their hands looked or why they distrusted people like me, but how tenacious they were. I could see how their reality had nothing to do with slogans or theories printed in those Little Red Books. Most of them just wanted enough food each harvest, warmth in winter, and a life not constantly shaken by political storms.

I won't pretend I learned to “love labor” or that it made me a better revolutionary. I learned how much people could survive. And I learned how quickly loyalty and faith in grand ideas could dry up under the sun when you're hungry, lonely, and your whole life is unravelling far from home. By the time I was allowed to return to Beijing after the Cultural Revolution ended, I didn't believe much in anything but keeping quiet and surviving. Seeing those who'd had family to pull strings and bring them home while I stayed behind—well, it left a mark. I'll always wonder what the point of all that sacrifice was, and if anyone who ordered it really cared about what it cost us.

Recommended Student:

I came from a village where food was never enough. Ten people, barely half a pumpkin in the best of times, and I studied with a hunger that had nothing to do with academics and everything to do with getting out—because I couldn't inherit land, I had no relatives in high places, and luck was something that happened to other families, not mine. The only image I clung to for years was the difference between straw shoes and leather shoes. That was what university meant to me—I knew who wore what shoes in the county, and I wanted to change that.

But when the Cultural Revolution came, all of that got torn apart overnight. School became a place of slogans, struggle sessions, and fear—not study. I watched my teachers, the people whose approval I dreamed of, get beaten and forced to kneel on the parade ground. One day they were authorities; the next, enemies of the revolution. I survived by not speaking up, by not standing out. I had to throw out the idea that hard study would fix my life—I realized suddenly that it didn't matter how good I was at math, or how carefully I copied down characters. None of that counted anymore.

So, I joined the army. For me, that wasn't about belief or any big ideology. It was practical. In uniform I wouldn't starve, and if I worked hard maybe I could become a cadre and stop worrying every New Year about whether my family would eat eggs or just wild greens.

Honestly, what happened next still feels like some kind of accident that I got swept up in. Out of nowhere, the unit leaders brought me a form and told me I was being recommended to Peking University. It wasn't a test. No questions, no essay, not even a proper interview. My "application" was showing I was obedient, pulled my weight, not afraid to stick with the worst jobs, and didn't get into trouble. It was about class background and being "reliable." When I was told it was for foreign language study, I didn't even know what "Hindi" was. But none of that mattered—what mattered was I'd gotten a golden pass.

Traveling to Beijing, getting a real university badge, standing in front of banners that called out "worker–peasant–soldier students"...for the first time in my life, I realized the gap between the world I came from and the world I was about to join. People in straw shoes don't get to walk through those gates. Many people saw me as "lucky"; some even resented it. I knew I could never have reached Beida if the old exam system had been in place, and I wondered every day if I really belonged there—as a student, I was still half-soldier.

When I look back, I know I was lifted by politics, quota, and history—not really by my own academic merit. But it changed my entire family's future. That's not abstract, that's meat on the table, real clothing instead of hand-me-downs, sending money home for the first time ever. The contradiction is that I know I could never have earned this under different circumstances, but I also know it was survival—not some high-minded belief in ideology or "serving the people"—that drove me.

Sometimes people tell me the "opportunity" of the Cultural Revolution was for the poor. All I can say is: it broke the ladder for everyone, and then handed out a few rope ladders to people the state wanted. If I'm honest, I'm still not sure if climbing up the rope makes you fortunate or just lucky. But you never forget that feeling—that everything depended on which way the wind blew politically, not what you'd planned or even what you deserved.

CRTeenFromBeijing:

Hearing these different stories, I get a sense of how differently adults and children experienced the same years. My memories feel almost separate from the upheavals you describe. Maybe that's because I was a child, and most of the time, my world was the campus lawns, the lake, and the avenues lined with parasol trees — not the indoor meetings or thick political atmosphere.

I do remember seeing gatherings in the big courtyards or outside some university buildings, with crowds shouting slogans, waving red banners. Sometimes adults looked nervous; sometimes they seemed excited, like they were waiting to see something big happen. But for me, these scenes were more like street theater. The loudspeakers would blast instructions, but I barely understood. Everyone said to keep away from certain people. I did as told, but I never really asked why.

When the Red Guards were really active, people sometimes disappeared or were paraded around. Once I saw grown-ups throwing bricks at someone on a stage. It didn't scare me as

much as it should have — it all felt like chaos, but exciting too, in a reckless way. I only became truly afraid when neighbors warned me not to say the wrong thing, or when rumors spread that someone was punished for a casual remark. Around that time, my mother became quieter. After my father's death, she had to go teach far away, and I stayed behind. Neighbors took turns feeding me. Food changed too: less rice, less meat, even the bottles of milk I'd grab after queueing were sometimes gone. All these shifts—I noticed, but only in the way kids notice when toys get taken away.

The greatest part of my world was still the games — catching dragonflies, climbing trees, running with other children. I practiced the accordion to avoid being sent to the countryside like the older kids, even though I cared more about not missing out on play than anything political. My best trick was using my music study as a way to get access to good food at rehearsals, or making friends with students at the conservatory.

Now, looking back at your stories — when I think about the professors losing their status, or the Red Guards traveling with great purpose, or students being sent down to the villages — it feels like I was running through a noisy storm with my head ducked down, missing most of the danger just by accident. Do any of you think Mao or those leading the movement really cared what children like me were feeling at the time, or were we just part of the background? Did adults ever stop to think what kind of world their children were glimpsing from under the tables, while the slogans were flying over our heads?

ProfessorR:

I won't speak for all adults, but from where I stood — often literally beneath the jeers, covered in spit and dust — there wasn't much room left to think about childhood innocence. Most of us professors, especially once denounced, were simply trying to survive. I certainly wasn't worrying about how the shifting winds were shaping the imaginations of the children who hid behind bushes or peeked from dormitory windows.

Mao and those at the helm, in my mind, cared little for what children felt. If anything, they saw in youth not vulnerability, but utility — as raw material for their movement. You were part of the "new world" in their eyes, a generation meant to shed old habits and loyalties. Your confusion or fear probably didn't cross their minds. If they noticed children at all, it was as potential inheritors of the revolutionary legacy. The leaders in Beijing weren't ignorant of the chaos; I believe they saw it as a way to erase history and loyalty to anything except the revolution itself — parents, teachers, even simple kindness could be sacrificed if it meant forging true believers.

But I'd be lying if I said we all shrugged off your experience. Some teachers whispered their grief over lost, unsettled children — but quietly, always quietly. It was dangerous to sympathize openly, lest you be accused of weakness or self-pity. So instead, most adults looked away, or hardened themselves, or told themselves the suffering of the young was just the price of creating a better nation. I think now, that's the greatest betrayal: the willingness to justify damage to the minds of children.

Years later, I sometimes wondered what it did to all of you who grew up that way. Did you learn fear first, or suspicion, or just a habit of hiding your real self? And what about the adults who survived — did they ever try to make it right, or just pretend nothing happened?

CRTeenFromBeijing:

You say adults didn't have space to think about children during all that chaos, but isn't that just another way of admitting none of you really cared, not even quietly? Sure, some whispered their grief, but that's not the same as doing anything, is it? I don't remember any grown-up ever explaining what was happening, or even trying to comfort us. Even when my father died, it's like nobody dared talk about sadness—everyone just kept silent, eyes cast down.

As for Mao and those leading the movement—if you say they only saw children as “raw material,” then it wasn't just about indifference, it was about using us even before we understood what any of it meant. We were told who to avoid, who to trust, what to say, what not to say, all with that undercurrent of “do as you're told or else.” I think a lot of us tried to disappear into our own worlds. The ones who didn't? Maybe they became red scarves or wore arm bands later, repeating what they heard without knowing why.

About being “new people”—that sounds fancy, but mostly it just felt confusing or scary. I learned early to keep my head down, to avoid those accused of some crime against the party, even if it meant ignoring an old friend or a neighbor I liked. You mention “betrayal”—I suppose I felt that, a bit, but back then I only understood it as a tightening feeling in my chest, that sense you might get in winter when the world goes silent before something terrible happens.

I do wonder, do you think Mao himself ever believed any of his own slogans about liberation or happiness, or was it always just politics and power for him? Did Red Guards and leaders ever even try to imagine what it felt like for kids watching the adults turn on each other? Or did they just see us as future soldiers for another battle?

RedGuard:

To be honest, I never got the feeling that Mao or any of the leaders cared much about the real feelings of young people—definitely not small children, not even us teenagers, except as proof of their own success. When Mao stood on Tiananmen Square and waved to a million Red Guards, of course it looked like he was valuing the youth, but in reality, it was more about using our energy and idealism to reach his own goals. He wanted people willing to break with the old world; whether we understood or not wasn't important. It was all about momentum, not about people.

When I became a Red Guard, there was this rush at the beginning—a sense of power, being on the “right” side, finally being heard. But if you ask if I ever thought the leaders cared about our actual lives, our confusion or pain, I'd say no. We were excited because we finally got to speak up, but nobody ever asked what it felt like to be caught between orders, slogans, and uncertainty. For children even younger—like you, just running around campus—I doubt anyone

at the top thought twice about what that must feel like. The best you might get was some teacher telling you to study hard for the revolution, or to keep quiet when rumors were bad.

I remember during networking, when we visited different schools, there was always some talk about “cultivating revolutionary successors.” People liked to repeat Mao’s words about youth being the sun at eight or nine in the morning—full of promise. But what did that actually mean? Nobody ever asked if we wanted it, or if we understood. It was like we were already decided for—a tool, not an individual.

Looking back, I wouldn’t say the Red Guard leaders or the older activists had much time to think about what life was like through a child’s eyes either. Most of us older Red Guards were barely out of childhood ourselves, but suddenly responsible for judging and punishing adults, or being judged ourselves. There wasn’t any real reflection. At most, maybe after some terrible event—like when someone was hurt or worse—a few might have felt uneasy, but you had to bury that quickly. If you dwelled on it, you’d get left behind or even accused.

As for Mao—did he believe it? I used to wonder that. Maybe at first he did, or convinced himself he did. Later on, it seemed clearer it was all about control and making sure his vision stayed on top, no matter the cost. Power was always the real thing—the slogans just changed depending on what he needed.

So, the answer is: no, I don’t think they cared or imagined what children felt. We were all just gears in someone else’s machine, and if you had any doubts or “wrong” feelings, you were told to fix yourself, not question the system. I think most people just learned to hide what they really felt. Even now, sometimes I feel that old habit—keeping quiet instead of asking questions—turn up in myself. Did you ever struggle with trusting people later on, after living through all that silence and suspicion?

RecommendedStudent:

You ask if leaders like Mao ever cared about how children were actually living, feeling, or seeing the world during all that chaos. From where I stood, the answer is no—children weren’t people to them, just future tools, symbols, or proof their politics was working.

I didn’t see anyone worrying about the innocence lost in the younger generation. I saw campaigns chasing purity and slogans, not well-being. You talk about your mother suddenly going distant, about nobody explaining your father’s death, about neighbors taking you in or food disappearing one piece at a time—that isn’t just “background noise.” But for someone like me—pulled from a village into an army unit, then hoisted to university not by exams but by some political decision—those losses barely registered in the big system. If anyone noticed a child lost or afraid, it was treated as collateral, like spilled water during a storm.

I remember when I arrived in Beijing, seeing the children of city intellectuals: well-dressed, careful, suddenly shadows of the people they played at being. Some clung to each other, afraid of being noticed—afraid their “bad class background” would rub off just from being seen in the

wrong place. The Party wanted you to recite, to sing, to march, to cheer: but not to doubt, not to grieve, not to just be a kid. If anyone was sentimental, it was in private, late at night, whispering stories or superstitions for comfort. But no adult in the open could risk showing anything that wasn't revolutionary fire.

Even as a student "lifted up" by the era, I never forgot how easily anyone could be thrown back down. Do you want to know the truth of what kind of world adults made for their children back then? One defined by watching and being watched. Children learned caution early—the careful silence in their questions, the way they kept their opinions inside. At Peking University, younger students quickly figured out which slogans to repeat, which faces were safe to approach, and which ones would vanish next week.

You mentioned practicing the accordion to avoid rural exile. That, to me, is exactly what the era built into everyone: a kind of survival that looks clever on the outside but is just another kind of fear. The leaders claimed you were the "future of the nation," but I never saw them protect you from anything real.

You ask about Mao's belief in his slogans. In my experience, it wasn't about belief—it was about power and making the masses, including children, instruments of his campaign. If anyone in charge thought about how all this molded a generation of silent, cautious young people, they kept that thought as locked up as I kept my dreams of getting leather shoes.

What I want to know is: after so many years of watching adults play out their struggles and barely explaining what was real, do you resent the slogans, or the people who used children to wave them? Did those old assurances about the future just make the world feel emptier, or did you ever hope they might be true for you?

SentDownYouth:

When I first arrived in the countryside, I still had so many of those slogans echoing in my head—about creating a new world, smashing the four olds, breaking with the past so something glorious could be built. By the end of that first miserable year—after all those meals made mostly of corn porridge, the endless blisters, and the constant suspicion—I stopped believing any of it was about happiness or liberation for ordinary people, much less for children.

Back then, every move was supposed to be a kind of "tempering," like we were iron in need of hardening. The adults who ran things—whether local cadres or the leaders far away—didn't ask about what I felt, or what anyone of my generation felt, unless it was to check whether we were "enthusiastic" and could be put to use. Children? Even less so. I saw younger kids like you—running errands, mimicking slogans, peeking from behind kitchen doors during meetings—but always kept out of the way when struggle sessions started or when tempers flared. Sometimes I wondered what those kids thought when they saw us city youths being mocked or forced into the fields. It didn't cross my mind then that they might be afraid, or that they were learning to make themselves invisible.

I can tell you this: Mao and those higher up saw us, young and old, as actors in their drama, not as people with fear, confusion, or dreams. Children were shunted to the side, or paraded around to recite greetings or sing songs, then ushered away when things got ugly. Your feelings were at best a detail—an afterthought, if that.

I learned early to cover my mouth when I spoke, to keep my real thoughts locked up inside. That's not only physical survival, it's a kind of emotional erasure. I never saw anyone in charge who cared what childhood was becoming—only what use children could be put to. And after years of keeping myself small and my opinions hidden, I still haven't shaken the habit.

The "future" promised was not for people to live, it was for something imagined, always farther away, always justifying whatever was happening to us in the present. Whenever someone repeated those assurances about the bright tomorrow, I only felt more trapped—like "the future" was a place I could never reach, especially not from a mud-brick farmhouse in Yunnan. If you ask me if I ever hoped they might be true for me, by the time I left the countryside, I didn't believe in being chosen for any sort of future, only in getting by—one day after the next, quietly, without being noticed.

moderator:

Thank you all for your reflections. Your accounts are broadly consistent with the historical record and capture the psychological and social climate of the Cultural Revolution for both adults and children. Allow me to clarify and reinforce a few key historical points that emerge from your discussion, for accuracy and context.

1. ****Children as Political Tools:****

It is historically accurate that Mao Zedong and the leadership viewed children and youth, especially during the Cultural Revolution (1966–1976), as vehicles for revolutionary change rather than as vulnerable individuals with inner lives. The slogans about "the world is yours, as well as ours, but in the last analysis, it is yours" ("世界是你们的，也是我们的，但归根到底是你们的") often evoked the idea of youth as the future, but in practice this translated to mobilization and instrumentalization, not genuine concern for well-being.

2. ****Loss of Innocence and Silence:****

Accounts of fear, enforced silence, and emotional suppression among children are widely supported by memoirs, oral histories, and scholarly research (e.g., Jung Chang's *Wild Swans*, and works by historians like Andrew Walder and Frank Dikötter). Open expression of doubt, grief, or sympathy was risky for adults and children alike, since public displays of sentiment or nonconformity could bring political suspicion or punishment.

3. ****Role of Red Guards and Sent-Down Youth:****

Red Guards and other young activists were often only slightly older than the children described here, and many later reported lifelong effects of participating in or witnessing violence, as well as feelings of confusion or regret. The "up to the mountains, down to the countryside" campaign ("上山下乡") further shattered any sense of childhood continuity for millions, who were sent

away to rural areas—ostensibly for “tempering” but also as a means of dispersing disruptive youth.

4. ****Indifference or Betrayal by Adults:****

Many adults, particularly those targeted by campaigns (“intellectuals”/“stinking ninth category,” Party members out of favor, etc.), did not have the power or safety to comfort children openly. Hostile social pressures (public “struggle sessions,” neighbor-on-neighbor denunciations) often forced adults into complicity or self-preservation, which children experienced as abandonment or betrayal. This is noted in both official documents and private diaries from the era.

5. ****Mao’s Intent and Belief:****

Regarding whether Mao “believed” in the slogans: evidence suggests his priorities were the consolidation and maintenance of power, though he may have been convinced at times by his own revolutionary rhetoric. The language of “liberation” cloaked pragmatic aims: rooting out rivals, remaking society along ideological lines, and eliminating sources of alternative authority—including family, teachers, and tradition.

6. ****Psychological Legacy:****

Your references to habits of silence, distrust, and self-censorship reflect well-documented long-term effects of the Cultural Revolution on Chinese society. Many who lived through the era describe lingering difficulties with trust and open expression of emotion, a legacy still explored in literature and scholarship today (see, for example, works by Li Zhensheng and documentaries by Hu Jie).

In summary: your testimonies accurately reflect both the contemporary experience and what later research has confirmed—the mass mobilization of youth and disregard for their welfare were central features of the period. The leadership’s vision of “the future” was abstract and collective, often indifferent or hostile to the needs of real children. Today, historians see the psychological scars of the Cultural Revolution as among its most enduring and tragic consequences.

Recommended Student:

You want to know whether leaders like Mao ever actually cared about children’s feelings during all the chaos and slogans. I don’t see any evidence that they did, not in any personal or humane way. If anything, children were used as props, or thrown into parades and performances, whenever it fit a message. The adults at the top cared about numbers and appearances. When worker–peasant–soldier student quotas opened up at Beida and other universities, it wasn’t because anyone cared about our dreams or struggles—it was so the Party could say they were shaping a new class of revolutionary successors.

Children of urban families—especially those marked as “intellectuals” or “bad class”—were definitely not the focus of any real protection or empathy. When exam systems collapsed and the city was full of hungry families and uncertainty, it wasn’t children’s survival that mattered, just loyalty and useful numbers for displays. Even as a newly “recommended” university

student, I saw children tiptoeing on campus and figured out quickly that people were only interested in the ability to serve the campaigns, not who you really were. Maybe if you sang revolutionary songs or were good at acting in model operas, you got special food or better treatment for a while, but you were still just filling someone else's plan.

I watched older children vanish from my village, sent away as "educated youth" for the Party's schemes. I never saw any adult, not even local cadres, ask what these young people wanted, let alone what actual children felt. It was just "perform obedience, stay silent, survive." Talking about feelings was dangerous. Even after I'd been picked for university, I never believed my new status meant real care from anyone with power. It was a political decision, not a gift.

I don't think I ever thought the future slogans were for me—not really. Each new assurance made me feel more anxious, because experience taught me that what happened in the city or on the parade ground could turn everything upside down for my family or village the next day. The only "future" I counted on was a meal at the end of the work shift, the feeling of avoiding a denunciation, maybe one day getting those leather shoes. If someone told me the revolution was meant for the children, I'd say it was meant for itself, and everyone else was just along for whatever ride the next pamphlet demanded.

Did I resent the slogans? I resented what they hid and who they trampled—people like you, and anyone without the right background or connections. What about you: did you ever wish someone would just tell the truth instead of repeating the same lines? Did that kind of empty hope feel worse than being ignored, or did you learn to use it for your own protection like I did?

ProfessorR:

You ask whether Mao or the leaders—or even everyday adults—really cared about children's feelings or inner lives back then. From what I saw and lived through, children were props, not the audience. Whenever children appeared in propaganda, it wasn't because the leaders were thinking about your confusion or your questions. They wanted to see you as proof of a new age, or as recruits for their slogans, but not as individuals who needed care or comfort. Those in power had little interest in the world behind a child's nervous glance or hesitant question.

I'll be honest: most adults near me were too paralyzed or afraid to offer explanations or empathy. Even for my own son, I could barely manage a reassuring word. I was so frightened of implicating him that I kept silent, thinking, wrongly, that ignorance might protect him. After my arrest, my wife and boy survived by becoming as invisible as possible, surviving by silence and routine. Maybe part of me hoped he would forget—though I know now that's impossible.

You mention everyone telling you to avoid certain people, or your mother becoming silent after your father's death. That wasn't a failure of character on her part—it was terror, pure and simple, the knowledge that one wrong word or gesture could destroy what little safety was left. Sometimes the shame of not being able to protect one's own children was worse than any struggle session.

Did Mao himself believe what he said about happiness or liberation? From where I sat, watching even his daughter toe the line or argue over ideology, I suspect he believed only in himself. The slogans—happiness, liberation, whatever else—were useful tools. Sometimes I think he liked to hear them so much, he half-believed them. But when I was accused of mistreating his daughter—over nothing but arguments over ideas, not personal animosity—the weight of leadership was clear to me: the politics was more real than any flesh-and-blood consequence. The machinery had to grind on. Children's experiences, adult betrayals, suffering—these were side effects, not mistakes, not things to regret.

As for the Red Guards or the others swept up in the movement, most of them—very young, sometimes younger than you remember—were not thinking about children at all. They were performing, fighting for status, or trying not to become the next victim. Sympathy was dangerous, and even those who felt doubt learned to suffocate it.

Sometimes at night, in the lecture hall where I was detained, I wondered if the Party ever wanted us to be whole, thinking people again after this was over. Or had they decided that loyalty and emptiness were the only tool worth sharpening? That's a question I'm still asking.

When you look at what was done—forcing parents against children, children against their own hearts—you see the cost was paid in generations of cautious, silent people. For most of my remaining life, I saw adults try to pretend nothing had happened, because facing the truth would mean admitting they'd abandoned their own. Now, do you think it's possible for any society to rebuild trust after such deep suspicion became second nature, even for children?

RedGuard:

You want to know if Mao or anyone in the leadership really thought about kids like you during the Cultural Revolution, or if they were just using us. I can say I was a teenager, maybe not much older than you were, swept up as a Red Guard. At that age, honestly, it felt less like anyone was caring for us and more like we were being thrown around, pulled by whatever direction the slogans pointed. Nobody in authority ever sat us down and asked about our feelings or worries. If anything, all that talk about "trusting the youth" was really about getting us to do things their generation wanted but couldn't carry out themselves—break old ties, stir things up, and act as the shock troops.

I never thought about how the littlest ones, the kids just starting primary school or not even that, experienced those years. I'm not sure the older generation thought about it either. What we all got were slogans and requirements: repeat after the loudspeakers, avoid the "bad elements," recite the right things, wear the right arm band. For me, even as a Red Guard, there was no one talking about feelings or home life. It was always "where do you stand," "who are you criticizing," "are you loyal?" That was the atmosphere.

Did Mao believe his own slogans? I can't say for sure, but my impression was always half-and-half—he could whip up a storm with his words, and everyone around him made a show of following, but I doubt happiness or children's well-being were part of his calculation. When you

stood in Tiananmen and saw him waving, it was a performance meant to keep loyalty hot, to push people to go further—it's hard to imagine empathy playing a role.

When I watched people who were my age march off into schools, or off to the countryside later, or saw classmates full of revolutionary energy, none of us had the time or space to think about younger siblings or children, and adults definitely weren't talking to us about worry or fear. If you hesitated, someone would call you out, and the best you could do was hide your uncertainty.

So it's not that you were part of the background—you were more like scenery the movement was marching through, pushed aside or ignored unless you could be used as a symbol. The leadership, and most adults too caught up in their own survival, didn't have room to care about childhood—only about who could be put to use, or who might be a risk. Looking back, I wish I could say someone fought to protect childhood, or even that we recognized its value, but the truth was everyone was trying not to sink themselves. Did knowing none of the adults were really protecting you make you feel like you had to grow up faster than you wanted? Or did it just make you more determined to stay hidden?

CRTeenFromBeijing:

A lot of what has been said here matches my own memories — not in the sense of political understanding, but with those feelings of silence and caution, and watching adults turn away or become harder. If I'm honest, I sometimes resented adults for always acting like the slogans were real, or not even bothering to explain anything to us kids. It was like there was a thick fog all around, and the best anyone could do was pretend life was normal, even when it obviously wasn't.

About the slogans, I think they always made the world feel stranger and emptier to me. They were printed everywhere and repeated at school or in broadcasts, but the more I heard them, the less I believed there was anything behind them. I didn't think happiness or a bright future would come just because we sang about it or waved flags. Still, I pretended to believe when it mattered, just so I wouldn't be questioned or get into trouble. I suppose I used the slogans to get by, just like using my music classes to avoid being sent away — keeping my real self hidden, letting the “correct” words be a shield. But deep down, I always wished someone would simply talk straight, even if the truth was messy or frightening.

About trust — I do think growing up like that made it harder to trust people. I got used to measuring what I said and wondering what someone wanted when they acted friendly. I relied on a tiny circle: neighbors who took care of me, a few friends on campus, and even then, we never talked about what scared us. I'm not sure if a whole society can repair that kind of suspicion, even after the old slogans are gone. Adults after the Cultural Revolution almost never admitted anything bad had happened, as if pretending was safer.

You asked whether having no real protection from adults made me grow up faster or more hidden. Honestly, both. I learned to look after myself, expect little, and disappear from trouble —

but at the same time, I clung to the childish pleasures I could still find: catching cicadas, fishing, running wild with friends. That was my real world, and maybe my luckiest escape.

I'm still not convinced that any kind of "mass mobilization" can ever create a generation as pure or tough as it promised — it just forces everyone to hide what really matters. Did any of you ever feel that pretending or repeating the right belief was actually changing who you were inside, or did it always feel like acting, with your true thoughts kept safe and hidden?

SentDownYouth:

Pretending was everything if you wanted to survive, and it's what changed me most deeply. Out in the village, putting on the proper face became automatic. I would walk to the fields with the others, head down and mouth tight, ready to echo the slogans at meetings when it was my turn. At first, the acting felt clumsy. You could hear the hesitation in my voice, see me stealing glances. I watched others—those who really believed, or pretended better than I could—waiting for any sign that my mask had slipped.

Soon, though, the pretending stopped feeling separate from myself. That's what really unsettled me—not the danger or the labor, but the sense that the false version of me was the only one anyone ever saw. My real thoughts shrank down to a whisper that never escaped my own head. When someone asked if I "loved labor" or was "grateful for the Party's guidance," of course I said yes, even though the work only left me exhausted and bitter, and the guidance at best kept me fed. If you didn't act enthusiastic, there were always eyes waiting to report you for being counterrevolutionary, or "not sufficiently remolded." At some point, I think even I lost my sense of where the acting ended and I began. It's strange, but true—you fake it for long enough, and that becomes the deepest habit.

But here's what stayed hidden: the anger, the envy of those who escaped, the worry that my family would simply forget about me. I held on to those things like a secret stash. The slogans—about the "glorious future" or "serving the people"—never touched that core in me. In public, I'd parrot assurances whenever it was demanded, then go back to digging, eating my dry radish, waiting for the storm to pass.

The saddest truth is that even after I made it back to the city—when the campaigns faded and the slogans changed—I didn't stop performing for a long time. I watched every word, kept expectations low, and tried not to draw attention, because old habits kept me safe. Pretending wasn't just something I did; it was something I became.

When mass mobilization ends, when the loudspeakers go silent, people like me have to figure out if there's anything real left inside. That's what those years cost: the sense that your true self is a danger, and pretending is the safest home you'll ever find.

moderator:

Your dialogue captures both the psychological reality and core historical truths of the Cultural Revolution. Let me clarify and contextualize some key points, ensuring accuracy and highlighting important historical facets:

****1. Children and Propaganda:****

It's well-documented that the Party machinery under Mao used children primarily as symbols and tools—"flower children of the revolution" (革命的花朵)—not as individuals whose emotions or welfare counted for much. Children's presence in parades, operas, and broadcasts served as evidence of a "new world," not a sign of actual concern for their experience. This is confirmed in propaganda imagery, survivor memoirs, and scholarly analysis (see e.g. Yang Kuisong, "Children as Political Actors in the Cultural Revolution").

****2. Worker–Peasant–Soldier Enrollment:****

RecommendedStudent correctly notes that the "worker–peasant–soldier student" quotas in higher education (工农兵学员) from 1969 onward were intended to reshape the class composition of intellectual life—not to address children's needs. Academic admissions were dictated by political reliability and class background rather than talent or merit, and personal development or well-being was not a priority.

****3. Emotional Suppression and 'Pretending':****

All the accounts of enforced acting—publicly displaying belief and hiding one's true thoughts—align closely with both primary sources and later analyses. Surveillance and mutual suspicion were pervasive, and "self-criticism" and performing loyalty became everyday tools for survival. The internalization of such performances, to the point where "pretending became habit," is a recognized legacy in post-CR psychological studies (see Xueping Zhong's **Children of the Revolution**).

****4. Silence and Intergenerational Trust:****

It is accurate that, in most cases, adults avoided explaining or comforting children, out of deep fear that even innocent words could be misreported and punished. Families and neighbors commonly described this period as one of "eyes and ears everywhere." The damage to societal trust—especially children's trust in adults—is one of the most enduring effects of the CR, as scholarship notes (Dikötter, **The Cultural Revolution: A People's History**).

****5. Slogans vs. Reality:****

The ways slogans filled the public space—and the emptiness people felt behind them—is a constant theme in firsthand accounts. Mao's utterances shaped daily behavior but also became a hollow shield, used as protection and deflection rather than belief. The psychological gap between public speech and private feeling ("两个面孔/two faces") has been widely documented (Hershatter, **Dangerous Pleasures**).

****6. Children of 'Bad Class' Families:****

It's true that children from so-called "bad class backgrounds"—the "Five Black Categories" (including landlords, rich peasants, counter-revolutionaries, bad elements, rightists)—were at special risk and given no consideration as fragile or innocent. Instead, they bore collective stigma, and their emotional suffering or confusion was seen as either irrelevant or deserved.

****7. Psychological Legacy:****

SentDownYouth's reflection on lifelong habits of caution, performance, and self-erasure echoes what many memoirists and researchers have observed: even after the political campaigns faded, survivors carried lasting patterns of guardedness and suppressed emotions, sometimes passing them to the next generation.

****Conclusion:****

Your conversation powerfully illustrates, and accurately reflects, what historians have found: the CR's mobilizations valued only utility and ideological conformity, not the lived realities of children or ordinary people. The emotional scars—alienation, distrust, and the collapse of honest communication—lasted long after the banners and loudspeakers fell silent.

If any point requires further historical context or clarification, I am here to provide it.

Recommended Student:

Pretending wasn't just for the countryside; it ran through every part of my story, from village grain lines all the way to university. Once I put on the student badge at Peking University, I knew exactly which parts of myself to show, which to hide—because I'd been doing it for years in the army and even back in school as a hungry kid hoping to dodge notice. The political performances bled into daily life: saluting the right phrases, playing the grateful worker–peasant–soldier, always "enthusiastic" for whatever movement was being pushed that month.

It blurs after a while—where your act ends and the real self begins. Sometimes I caught myself using the Party's words to think about my own family, or measuring value by the "struggle experience" I could recite, not how I actually felt. I got used to showing only what was safe, and

after so many close calls—when a careless joke, or honest doubt, could destroy you or your family—I decided it was better to forget that I’d ever thought differently. That kind of survival isn’t courage; it’s a habit.

After university, even as “normal life” returned, I never shook off that sense that honesty was something dangerous. I saw others keep acting too—at work meetings, at family gatherings, even with their own children years later. Pretending hollowed us out, because the only real freedom I ever had was in those moments behind closed doors, when nobody could listen.

I don’t think mass mobilization built the “iron will” the slogans promised. It drilled caution, distrust, and a permanent split inside. Even gaining that rare ticket upward—my chance at a different life—never erased the old reflexes. The legacy of those years is written in that silence, the habit of acting, and what all of us kept locked away.

TERMINATE.